

COVER



Grok the Rock

Three Quiet Stories

Being · Mending · Seeing

① Cover: *Grok the Rock*¹, a small gray limestone creature with moss on his head, sits on a smooth rock under a soft-leaved tall tree beside a glowing water-hole in warm outback light.

DEDICATION

For every explorer, small and large,
grokking the world in their own gentle way.

And for every small feeling
that needs only seeing,
every break set for mending
that needs only tending,
and for every true word
that stands though unheard.

With thanks to Original Grokkers:
Robert A. Heinlein "Stranger in a Strange Land"
Ted Prior "Grug"

Grok = Stranger in a Strange Land + Grug
("Grug" cleans up "Stranger" for children *and* adults)

① Dedication page: three tiny versions of *Grok the Rock*³ sit side by side on a smooth stone at the bottom of a nearly blank warm cream page.

PAGE 2

*Grok the Rock*⁵ woke under the tall tree.
Sun was warm on his limestone back.
Grok felt happy.

He looked at the wide world
as if he was seeing it for the very first time.

① *Grok the Rock*⁶ sits up under the tall tree in warm morning sun, limestone back lit by golden shafts, gazing out at the wide world with gentle wonder.

TITLE & CREDITS

Grok the Rock²

Three Quiet Stories

Being · Mending · Seeing

Draft Story, Image Prompts with Grok 4.5 from xAI
Illustrations with Grok Imagine from xAI
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Companion to *Hai Ikthiss: Three Tall Tales*

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One - Being

Grok and the Small Feeling

① Chapter One, Being — Grok and the Small Feeling. *Grok the Rock*⁴ sits at the roots of a tall soft-leaved tree, holding a small pebble with quiet curiosity in early morning light.

PAGE 3

Soon he walked to the water-hole.
A tall emu was already there.
The emu stretched his long neck and said,
"I am the tallest. Stand behind me."

① Beside a clear water-hole, a tall proud emu stretches its neck high while small *Grok the Rock*⁷ stands nearby, looking up at the scale difference.

Then a wombat rolled up, round and solid.
 “I am the strongest,” said the wombat.
 “Everyone watch me dig.”
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 Grok tried to dig too.
 His hole was small.
 He felt smaller than the hole.

① A sturdy wombat digs a large hole in red earth; tiny *Grok the Rock*⁸ digs a much smaller uneven hole and looks down at it.

A kookaburra laughed from a branch.
 “Look at little Grok! So short! So stony!”
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 The small feeling grew inside Grok.
 It felt like a heavy cold pebble in his middle.

① *Grok the Rock*⁹ stands slightly hunched while a kookaburra laughs from a branch above; a soft cool pebble-shape hints at the feeling in his middle.

He wanted to make himself look bigger.
 He stood on a log.
 He puffed out his chest.
 He even tried to thump the ground like the kangaroo.
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 It only made the cold pebble heavier.

① *Grok the Rock*¹⁰ stands unsteadily on a log with his chest puffed out, trying to look big, little stone feet thumping the wood.

That night Grok sat alone by a little fire.
 He put his arms around his knees.
 He let the small feeling stay.
 He did not run from it.
 He did not throw it at anyone else.
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 Slowly the feeling softened,
 like clay left in the sun.
 He began to understand it.

① At night *Grok the Rock*¹¹ sits alone by a tiny campfire under a soft starry sky, arms around his knees, peaceful and accepting.

Next morning Grok went back to the water-hole.
 He did not climb on anything.
 He did not try to be taller or louder.
 He simply drank,
 then sat on a warm rock and hummed.
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 Nothing big had changed outside.
 But everything felt lighter inside.
 He was beginning to grok himself.

① Next morning *Grok the Rock*¹² sits contentedly on a sun-warmed rock by the water-hole, quietly humming, at ease in his own size.

He spent the day making a soft nest of leaves and moss
 just the right size for a small rock fellow.
 When it was finished he smiled.
 It was small.
 It was his.
 It was enough.
 ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■
 From that day, when the cold pebble tried to grow again,
 Grok sat still until it became quiet.
 He just stayed Grok.
 And that felt like the best size of all.

① *Grok the Rock*¹³ finishes a cosy round nest of leaves and moss just his size, smiling with simple contentment in soft afternoon light.

Chapter Two - Mending

Grok Tends It

① Chapter Two, Mending — *Grok Tends It*. *Grok the Rock*¹⁴ gently holds a cracked melon with both small hands, kind and steady.

*Grok the Rock*¹⁵ woke under the tall tree.
 Grok watched his little garden of melons and sweet potatoes.
 He loved watching them grow.
 Every new leaf felt like a small wonder.

① On a sunny morning under the tall tree, *Grok the Rock*¹⁶ stands among healthy melon vines and sweet potato leaves with quiet delight.

That afternoon his friend,
a young echidna named Pip,
hurried through the garden looking behind him
and knocked over the best melon vine.

The big melon split open on the ground.
Seeds and sweet juice spilled everywhere.

① *Pip the young echidna freezes mid-step in horror as a big melon splits open at Grok's feet, juice and seeds spilling on the garden ground.*

Pip froze.
His spines trembled.
"I ruined it," he whispered.
"You will be angry. Everyone will be angry."

Some bush creatures gathered.
"Make him go away," muttered a possum.
"He should bring you three new melons," said a lizard.

① *Pip curls in shame while Grok the Rock¹⁷ stands kind and concerned; a few bush animals gather nearby looking judgmental.*

Grok looked at the broken vine.
He looked at Pip's worried eyes.

He did not raise his voice.
He did not point his finger.
He picked up a digging stick
and began to make soft earth ready.

"Come," said Grok gently.
"We plant new seeds together."

① *Grok the Rock¹⁸ kneels and offers a digging stick to Pip with open kindness; Pip slowly uncurls as hope returns to his eyes.*

Pip blinked.
Then he came close.
Together they planted.
Together they watered.
Together they built a little fence of twigs
so no one would step there again by mistake.

① *Grok the Rock¹⁹ and Pip work side by side planting seeds, watering, and building a tiny twig fence, both with soft smiles.*

While they worked, Pip told Grok
he had been running because bigger creatures
had been chasing him and laughing.
He had not seen the vine.

The next days Pip came every morning.
He became the best water-carrier in the valley.
The new vines grew strong,
even stronger than the old ones,
because two friends cared for them.

① *Pip waters thriving new melon vines with a leaf bucket while Grok the Rock²⁰ watches nearby with quiet pride.*

When other small accidents happened
(as they always do),
Grok remembered the melon.
He helped the one who felt hurt.
He also stayed kind to the one who had done the bumping.

No one was sent away.
No one carried a long heavy hurt.
They just tended to what was broken
and the friendship felt sturdier,
right at the mended place.

Grok learned that a garden,
and a friendship,
do not stay alive by never breaking.
They stay alive by being gently put back together.

① *At golden hour Grok the Rock²¹ and Pip sit beside thriving melons with another small animal included, a peaceful mended community.*

Chapter Three - Seeing

Grok and the True Word

① *Chapter Three, Seeing — Grok and the True Word. Two reed baskets side by side: one fancy and tipped, one plain and full; Grok the Rock²²'s small hand rests near the good basket.*

The very next day creatures came to look.
A glossy black cockatoo with grand tail feathers landed nearby.
“That basket is clever,” said the cockatoo,
“but *my* idea for a basket would be far finer.
After all, I have the grandest feathers,
so my thoughts must be the grandest too.”

Some younger animals nodded hard.
They always nodded when the cockatoo spoke.
His voice was as grand as his feathers.

① *A glossy black cockatoo with grand tail feathers perches high and speaks proudly while Grok the Rock²⁵ holds his basket below.*

Grok tried both ideas.
The cockatoo's way looked fancy
but the basket tipped and leaked.

The old tortoise's small idea
made Grok's basket comfortable
and steady for everyone.

① *Side by side: a fancy feathered basket tips and leaks, while a simpler steady basket is easy to carry; Grok the Rock²⁷ looks thoughtfully between them.*

Grok the Rock²³ woke under the tall tree.

Grok liked making useful things,
and that day he worked on a water basket
woven from reeds and lined with soft clay.
By evening it held water without one drip.

He turned it in his hands
and felt the quiet joy of a thing well made.

① *At golden hour under the tall tree, Grok the Rock²⁴ turns a finished reed water basket lined with clay, clear water sparkling inside.*

Later a very old tortoise spoke in a slow soft voice.
He suggested the small change of a handle,
making it easy to carry for friends less sturdy than Grok.
His shell was plain. No one special.
A few animals turned away because the tortoise was not famous.

① *A humble old tortoise with a plain shell speaks softly about a handle idea while Grok the Rock²⁶ listens carefully; some animals turn toward the flashy cockatoo.*

Grok sat with the two baskets side by side.
He did not look at feathers.
He did not look at age or fame.
He only looked at which basket held water best
and felt kindest in the hand.

He kept the better way.
Then he left both the good basket
and the plain pattern for weaving it
under the big tree for anyone to use or copy.
No name on it. No “ask me first.”

① *Grok the Rock²⁸ places the sturdy good basket and a plain weaving pattern under the tall tree for anyone to use, open and free.*

Some animals still waited to hear what the cockatoo thought
before they decided if a thing was good.

But more and more little ones
began to try things for themselves.

They listened to Grok's quiet words
the same way they listened to the grand cockatoo's words,
and then they tested everything with their own paws.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

They were grokking the true, the what not the who.

① *Young animals carefully test baskets with their own paws; the cockatoo is off to the side while **Grok the Rock**²⁹ smiles quietly in the background.*

Grok felt peaceful.
He did not need the biggest voice.
He only needed true things.
And Grok saw that true things
could come from a grand bird
or a dusty tortoise
or a small rock fellow under a tree.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

As long as someone was free to say
“that does not work”
and still stay welcome in the valley,
the true word could keep walking
on its own strong legs.

① *At golden hour **Grok the Rock**³⁰ sits contentedly under his tall tree with the good basket beside him as animals of all kinds move freely together.*

CLOSING

And so **Grok the Rock**³¹ stayed
a small limestone fellow
who could sit with a small feeling,
who mended what broke,
and who let every true word
stand on its own legs.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

The valley felt safer
because he did.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

He kept exploring gently.
And the world kept teaching him.

① *Closing page: a wide peaceful valley at dusk with tiny **Grok the Rock**³² sitting on his favourite rock, soft stars beginning to appear.*

COVER



Hai Ikthiss

Three Tall Tales

Being · Mending · Seeing

① *Cover: Lord **Hai Ikthiss**¹, a vast kind living tall tree with a gentle face in the upper trunk, stands over a forested valley spring while small creatures look up through soft mist.*

TITLE & CREDITS

Hai Ikthiss²

Three Tall Tales

Being • Mending • Seeing

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Companion to Grok the Rock: Three Quiet Stories

DEDICATION

**For every life that grows toward the light,
and every hand that reaches down to lift.**

And for every empty cheer
that still needs true seeing,
every high place
that still needs mending below,
and for every living water
that finds the lowest root.

With thanks to Original Tall Tellers:
J.R.R. Tolkien "The Lord of the Rings"
Ted Prior "Grug"
and every quiet seed that learned to walk

① Dedication page: three tiny green sprouts beside a single clear water drop on a nearly blank warm cream page; optional tiny soft silhouette of **Hai Ikthiss**³ the tall tree far in cool mist.

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One - Being

Hai and the Empty Praise

① Chapter One, Being — *Hai and the Empty Praise*. **Hai Ikthiss**⁴ as a vast living tall tree with a kind face fills the upper page while small valley creatures look upward in bright praise.

PAGE 2

Hai Ikthiss⁵ ruled the forest from atop the tall tree.
He was the first tree in the valley.
When the valley was empty, he stood alone.
Rain found him first.
Then grass.
Then birds.

① Dawn over a young forested valley: **Hai Ikthiss**⁶ stands as a single tall living tree with a gentle face, roots drinking a bright new spring, first grasses and one small bird arriving.

PAGE 3

Soon the valley filled with life.
A stag lifted his antlers and called,
"Lord Ikthiss is the tallest!
We are lucky he stands for us!"

Everyone cheered.
No one looked up into his eyes.

① A proud stag with high antlers cheers at the roots of tall **Hai Ikthiss**⁷ while other creatures join the praise; no one looks up into the tree's eyes.

PAGE 4

A badger ambled up, solid and strong.
"Lord Ikthiss is the strongest root!"
he said. "Everyone thank the tree!"

They thanked the shade.
They thanked the height.
They did not thank the heart inside the wood.

① A sturdy badger bows toward the great trunk of **Hai Ikthiss**⁸, praising the strongest root, while creatures thank shade and height without seeing his face.

A raven called from a branch.
 “Look how grand our Lord Ikthiss is!
 So high! So giving!”

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

The praise grew loud as rain.
 But Hai felt a hollow place
 high in his middle,
 like a cup no one had filled.

① *A bright raven calls grand praise from a branch while Hai Ikthiss⁹'s upper trunk shows a soft hollow glow, like an empty cup needing water.*

He could have asked for more cheers.
 He could have shaken his branches
 until every creature bowed lower.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

He did not.
 He only listened to the spring
 and felt the hollow cup wait.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Something in him wanted a hook
 to the ground — a living join —
 not more noise from below.

① *Hai Ikthiss¹⁰ stands still and kind, one long root or low branch gently reaching toward the ground spring, listening rather than only receiving praise.*

That night Hai sat with the stars in his leaves.
 He let the hollow cup stay.
 He did not fill it with louder praise.
 He did not tip it onto anyone else.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Slowly the hollow softened,
 like dry earth when first water finds it.
 He began to understand it.

① *At night under a deep starry sky, Hai Ikthiss¹¹'s canopy holds the stars while a soft hollow in the upper trunk slowly warms and glows.*

Next morning the valley still cheered.
 Hai Ikthiss¹² still gave shade and fruit and quiet rain-catch.
 Nothing big had changed outside.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

But everything felt clearer inside.
 He was beginning to know
 what the hollow cup was for.
 It was not for collecting praise.
 It was for pouring himself down.

① *Morning gold lights Hai Ikthiss¹³'s gentle face as he looks down his trunk toward the roots, clearer inside while the valley still cheers below.*

He spent the day sending extra water
 to the smallest roots and thirstiest ferns.
 When he finished he smiled a tree-smile.

The gifts were large.
 The thanks were loud.
 The knowing was enough.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

From that day, when the hollow cup tried to grow again,
 Hai stayed still until it became quiet.
 He just stayed Hai.
 And he began to plan a smaller way.

① *Hai Ikthiss¹⁴ sends soft streams of water and gentle light down to tiny ferns and small animals at the roots, smiling a simple tree-smile of contentment.*

Chapter Two - Mending

Kai Walks Below

① *Chapter Two, Mending — Kai Walks Below. A small living walking seed-creature with a sprout-tuft and kind eyes stands at the foot of the great tall tree; the small figure is Hai Ikthiss¹⁵ in humble seed form.*

Hai Ikthiss¹⁶ ruled the forest from atop the tall tree.
 Then one quiet morning he climbed down.
 He left the crown empty of his face
 and walked the ground as a living walking seed.

The animals found him among the melons.
 “Who are you?” they asked.
 “You can call me Kai,” he said,
 and smiled a patient seed-smile.

① *In an English moss-and-fern garden at the tall tree's roots, Hai Ikthiss¹⁷ in humble Kai form—a small living walking seed—smiles among cantaloupe vines.*

That afternoon his friend, a young hedgehog named Pip,
 hurried through the garden looking behind him
 and knocked over the best melon vine.
 The big melon split open on the ground.
 Seeds and sweet juice spilled everywhere.

① *Pip the young hedgehog freezes mid-step in horror as a big cantaloupe splits open on the ground; Kai (Hai Ikthiss¹⁸ as living walking seed) stands small and steady among the spilled seeds.*

Pip froze.
 His spines trembled.
 “I ruined it,” he whispered.
 “You will be angry. Everyone will be angry.”

Some wood folk gathered.
 “Make him go away,” muttered a fox.
 “He should bring three new melons,” said a stoat.

① *Pip curls in shame while Kai (small living walking seed form of Hai Ikthiss¹⁹) stands kind and still; a fox and stoat among the wood folk look harsh and judgmental.*

Kai looked at the broken vine.
 He looked at Pip's worried eyes.

He did not raise his voice.
 He did not point his finger.
 He picked up a digging stick
 and began to make soft earth ready.

“Come,” said Kai gently.
 “We plant new seeds together.”

① *Kai (Hai Ikthiss²⁰ as small living walking seed) kneels and offers a digging stick to Pip with open kindness; Pip slowly uncurls as hope returns.*

Pip blinked.
 Then he came close.
 Together they planted.
 Together they watered.
 Together they built a little fence of twigs
 so no one would step there again by mistake.

① *Kai and Pip plant and water side by side and build a tiny twig fence around new seeds, both gently smiling.*

While they worked, Pip told Kai
 he had been running because bigger creatures
 had been chasing him and laughing.
 He had not seen the vine.

The next days Pip came every morning.
 He became the best water-carrier in the valley.
 The new vines grew strong,
 even stronger than the old ones,
 because two friends cared for them.

① *Pip waters thriving new melon vines while Kai watches with quiet pride; the tall tree stands peaceful above the English garden.*

When other small accidents happened
 (as they always do),
 Kai remembered the melon.
 He helped the one who felt hurt.
 He also stayed kind to the one who had done the bumping.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

No one was sent away.
 No one carried a long heavy hurt.
 They just tended to what was broken
 and the friendship felt sturdier,
 right at the mended place.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Hai Ikthiss²¹ learned, walking as Kai,
 that a garden, and a friendship,
 do not stay alive by never breaking.
 They stay alive by being gently put back together.

① *At golden hour Kai and Pip sit beside thriving melons with another small creature included, a peaceful mended garden community.*

Chapter Three - Seeing

Hai and the Far Sight

① *Chapter Three, Seeing — Hai and the Far Sight. A kind walking tall tree offers both hands downward to lift; small creatures look up with wonder.*

Hai Ikthiss²² ruled the forest from atop the tall tree.
 Two years had turned.
 He was home in the crown again.
 But the valley had changed its song.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Creatures who once cheered
 now whispered at the roots.
 “He is too high,” they said.
 “What if the tall one wants too much?”

① *Two years later **Hai Ikthiss**²³ is home in the crown again at golden hour, but creatures whisper fearfully at the roots instead of cheering.*

A glossy pheasant with grand tail feathers landed nearby.
 “Stay low,” said the pheasant.
 “Tall things fall. Grand feathers know best.”

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Some younger animals nodded hard.
 They always nodded when the pheasant spoke.
 His fear sounded as grand as his feathers.

① *A glossy pheasant with a long spectacular tail perches mid-height and warns others to stay low while **Hai Ikthiss**²⁴ high above stays kind and still.*

Later a very old owl spoke in a slow soft voice.
 “I remember Kai,” he said.
 “The small seed who planted with Pip.
 Kind hands do not change when they grow tall.”

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

A few animals turned away
 because the owl was not famous.
 Hai listened all the way down his trunk.

① *A very old plain owl speaks softly of remembering kind Kai, while **Hai Ikthiss**²⁵ listens all the way down his trunk with open attention.*

Hai Ikthiss²⁶ did not shout them quiet.
 He did not shake the pheasant from the branch.
 He stepped out of still wood
 and became a walking tall tree —
 long kind limbs, deep root-feet,
 a face they could meet at last.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Not to tower.
 To come near.

① ***Hai Ikthiss**²⁷ steps gently out of still wood into a living walking tall tree—long kind limbs, deep root-feet, a meetable face animals can finally see.*

Some animals stepped back.
 Pip did not.
 Pip remembered the melon
 and the digging stick
 and the new seeds.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Hai bent like a bridge of wood and kindness.
 “Come,” he said.
 “Not under me.
 With me.”

① *Hai Ikthiss²⁸ bends like a bridge of wood and kindness with one great hand open low; Pip steps forward while some other creatures half-hide and watch.*

He lifted Pip first —
 not to show power,
 but to share the view.
 Then he lifted the owl.
 Then the ones who had feared him.
 Even the pheasant, when the pheasant was ready.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Each friend rose to Hai's height
 and became a giant with him —
 same face, same heart,
 only the eyes now level with the far hills.

① *Hai Ikthiss²⁹ lifts willing friends—Pip, the owl, others, even the pheasant—to shared giant height, same faces, eyes now level with wonder.*

From the high quiet air
 they saw the whole valley at once —
 the woodland pool, the old garden,
 the places praise had been loud
 and the places fear had been small.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Hai felt peaceful.
 He did not need the tallest cheer.
 He only needed true friends
 who could see as far as love can see.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

As long as someone was free to say
 “I was afraid”
 and still be lifted welcome,
 the far sight could keep walking
 on many strong legs.

① *On a high ridge at golden hour, Hai Ikthiss³⁰ and his giant friends look out together over the whole peaceful forested valley.*

And so Hai Ikthiss³¹ stayed
 a living tall fellow
 who could sit with an empty cup of praise,
 who mended what broke from below,
 and who lifted every willing friend
 to shared far sight.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

The valley felt wider
 because he did.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Now everyone could see as far as Hai.

■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

He kept pouring gently.
 And the world kept growing him.

① *Closing page: wide forested valley at peaceful dusk with Hai Ikthiss³² as a kind walking tall tree among gentle giant friends on a soft rise, stars beginning to appear.*